

Asymptomatic Bacteriuria

WARWIKI

Patient Information · Bacteria in the urine when you feel completely fine

Asymptomatic bacteriuria means a urine test found **bacteria in your urine, but you have no urinary symptoms**. You have no burning, urgency, pain or fever. This is common, especially in older adults. In most people it is **not an infection that needs treatment**. This sheet explains why your team may decide **not** to give antibiotics.

What It Means

Harmless bacteria can live in the bladder without causing trouble. Finding them on a test does **not**, by itself, mean you are sick. It is a **urinary tract infection (UTI)** only when it causes **symptoms**, such as burning, urgency, new pain or fever.

Why We Usually Don't Treat It

Major medical guidelines advise **against** antibiotics for bacteria found without symptoms. Treating it:

- Does **not** make you feel better, because you already feel well
- Can cause **side effects**, such as rash, upset stomach or a serious diarrhea called *C. diff*
- Leads to **antibiotic resistance**, so future infections are harder to treat

So a "positive" urine test in someone who feels fine is usually best left alone.

Learn the Terms

Asymptomatic

Without any symptoms.

Bacteriuria

Bacteria in the urine.

UTI

A urinary tract infection: bacteria *plus* symptoms.

Urine culture

A test that grows bacteria from a urine sample.

Antibiotic resistance

When bacteria change so antibiotics stop working.

Watchful waiting

Keeping an eye on things instead of treating, when treatment is not needed.

So why was my urine tested? Sometimes urine is checked for another reason. If it shows bacteria but you feel fine, your team is following the evidence by holding antibiotics. They are not ignoring you. There are a few times when treatment *is* recommended.

When It Is Treated

Antibiotics **are** recommended, even without symptoms, in two main cases:

- **Pregnancy.** Treating it protects you and the pregnancy.
- **Before some urology procedures** that are expected to cause bleeding in the urinary tract.

Otherwise, watchful waiting is the safe path. Cloudy or strong-smelling urine alone is **not** a reason for antibiotics.

What to Watch For

Treatment is based on **symptoms**. Know the signs of a true UTI:

- New **burning** or pain when you urinate
- A new, strong **urge to go**, or going much more often
- **Fever, chills, or pain in your side or back**

Good to Know

- In older adults, new confusion with no fever or urinary symptoms is often **not** from a UTI. Other causes should be checked first.
- If you have a catheter, some bacteria are expected. They are not treated unless you have symptoms.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- New burning, a strong urge to go, or new pain low in the belly
- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, chills, or pain in your side or back
- Blood in the urine

Go to an emergency department if:

- You have a fever and feel faint, confused or very unwell
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Bacteria in the urine **without symptoms** is common and usually **not** treated.
2. Treating it does not help you feel better. It can cause side effects and resistance.
3. Pregnancy and some urology procedures are the main exceptions.